

‘THE PERSONAGES THAT SPEAKE’

Playing with Parts in Early Printed Drama

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Introduction

On the title page of *Lusty Juventus* (?1550), following a list of ‘The Personages that Speake’, the reader is informed ‘foure may play it easely, takyng such par|tes as they thinke best: so that any one tak| of those partes that be not in place at once’.¹ Such instructions would seem to make clear that the text, as printed, is intended for any would-be acting troupe with the aim of facilitating performance. Similar instructions for the division of parts can be found in around a quarter of all 79 fully extant plays printed before the opening of The Theatre in London in 1576, and have lead Paul Voss to reach a similar conclusion.² Arguing that early printed ‘plays were not *primarily* intended to be read’, he has suggested that they functioned instead as ‘a “do-it-yourself” form of entertainment’.³ However, perhaps as interesting as the inclusion of these guides to doubling is the fact that they can be misleading; in more than one case the indicated number of players simply does not tally with the requirements of the plot.⁴ Noting these discrepancies, Greg Walker has suggested that such claims about cast size were often ‘no more than token assertions of their playability’, the work of printer-entrepreneurs keen to exploit the market potential of their wares.⁵ Actors may have been one potential consumer base, but character lists furnished with doubling instructions could also serve to inscribe the dramatic nature of the text, authenticating the book as a play over and above any other genre of text. Put another way, in an era before playgoing had grown to become a popular leisure-time activity, the division of parts could also serve to highlight to potential buyers or readers the genre of the text in their hands. In short, while the character list has often been put forward as primary exhibit in the case against early printed drama as literature, even when such lists seem to point conclusively towards performance, it may be that the horizons of reception are broader than we have hitherto assumed. With Emma Smith, I have recently traced the multifarious forms and functions of character lists in plays printed before the closing of the theatres in 1642.⁶ Drawing on our observations, the purpose of this article is to delineate in more

detail the ways in which character lists were used to appeal to different kinds of readership before the era of professional playhouse plays and playing. In doing so, I hope to challenge the accepted view that such plays were not intended for readerly consumption.

In the discussion that follows, I delineate three categories of character list: lists with doubling instructions; lists associated with so-called 'closet' plays; and lists that provide descriptions for each of the characters. To facilitate cross-reference, lists of plays associated with each of these categories are provided as Appendix I.

A Potted History of the Character List

With just two notable exceptions, vernacular medieval plays fully extant in contemporary manuscripts are not provided with character lists.⁷ Nor do such lists appear in manuscript or incunable versions of classical plays by Terence, Plautus, or Seneca. But, if we discount plays for which the only witnesses are fragmentary, just sixteen single-play playbooks printed before 1576 do not have a character list.⁸ Moreover they occur in every play printed after 1565. Their ubiquity, however, can be pushed back still further, since with two exceptions, all plays printed after 1535 without character lists are new editions of older plays and follow the paratextual precedent of earlier editions. But, if the inclusion of a character list had become the norm within the first decades of dramatic print, it is striking that in the years following the establishment of professional playhouses the practice was far less widely adopted; between 1590 and 1620, just a third of printed plays provide character lists.⁹ While it is not the aim of this article to explain these statistics in any great depth, they do reveal two important trends. First, that character lists are primarily a print phenomenon — that is, while they do occur in manuscript form, it is clear that in the majority of such cases, print rather than scribal practice is the model. And second, that there exists a special relationship between character lists and pre-playhouse drama — printed character lists continue to be used in a variety of inventive ways after the establishment of commercial theatres in London in the 1570s, but only in the decades preceding this development was the inclusion of such lists so pervasive. To these observations we may also tentatively add that the character list, at least in its earliest forms, might be recognised as a peculiarly vernacular paratext. While space does not permit a more extensive analysis of the broader European context, the inclusion of a character list in John Rastell's *The Nature of the Four Elements* (?1520) — the first printed play to include such a list — marks an

independent development from Classical and other continental traditions that would soon be adopted by all English plays printed before the late 1570s.

Positioning the Character List

When Rastell printed an edition of his play, he made the unprecedented move of including a character list on the title page — the three manuscript character lists that pre-date *The Nature of the Four Elements* all appear after the texts of the plays themselves.¹⁰ But the decision to bring the list to the fore was a logical choice — as playbooks would have been sold unbound, the character list could function in tandem with the title page's other features to attract potential buyers. In fact, the title page remained the most common position for character-lists across our period, accounting for around sixty percent of all occurrences. Almost all other character lists are also to be found before the text, often among other front matter, the extent and complexity of which is often determined by the nature of the play to follow. Just two plays experiment with an alternative back position for their lists, and their early dates — *Magnificence* was printed in (?)1530 and *Nature* in (?)1530–1534 — indicate that their printers may have been working with early manuscript rather than print examples in mind. If these two examples stand out as exceptions which prove that print conventions for the position of character lists were established relatively early, the case of John Bale's *Three Laws* provides further, tantalising evidence. For while the character list appears among the front matter in both editions, the doubling instructions that occur on sig. G1^v in the first (c. 1547) edition are repositioned in the second (1562) edition to appear on the title page.¹¹ It is a change that at once highlights the functional proximity of character lists and doubling instructions, and reflects one printer's efforts to ensure that his edition of this particular play met with the market's expectations.¹²

If the print history of the character list suggests that certain conventions had been fixed by the middle of the sixteenth century, manuscript examples from across our period paint a more complicated picture. For while a number retain the back position favoured by the earliest manuscript playbooks, still others occur on the title page or amongst other prefatory materials. In the most striking example that I have found, two copies of the same play, *Gismond of Salem*, adopt different approaches. The earlier, British Library MS Hargrave 205 (copied c. 1568–1575), includes a character list on fol. 22^v at the end of the manuscript,

immediately after other, more typically prefatory material — dedicatory verses and an argument. The later, BL MS Lansdowne 786 (copied late sixteenth/early seventeenth century) places all this material at the front between fols 3^r and 5^v. In addition, a further fragmentary witness, Folger MS V. a. 198, a miscellany of mainly poetic materials copied around 1570, adopts the layout preferred by the Hargrave manuscript. There are no entries in the Stationers' Company Records for a play of *Gismond* in the middle decades of the sixteenth century, but the scribes who copied these manuscripts seem to have had a very clear sense of what a play ought to look like in the second half of the sixteenth century. Moreover, the rearrangement of the paratextual apparatus in the Lansdowne manuscript suggests the work of a scribe keen to keep up with print conventions. In short, while the position of the earliest printed character lists may have been influenced by scribal habits, in the case of some, later manuscripts the obverse seems to have been true — the frontal position of character lists in a handful of mid- and late-sixteenth-century manuscript playbooks is evidence of just one of the many ways that scribes modelled their work on the form and layout of printed texts.

Character Lists and the Target Markets

Having made some very general observations about the history of the character list and its conventional appearance in manuscript and print playbooks, in the remainder of this article I want to show how different forms may have been utilised to appeal to different target markets. Indeed, that such lists exist in such a range of different forms suggests something of the complexity of choices available to playbook makers, and shows, at the most basic level, that printers had, even within the first decades of dramatic publication, a keen sense of how to harness different markets. For now, let us return to the position I introduced at the opening of this article: that character lists provide the clearest indication that the primary consumers of early playbooks were would-be actors. It is a view that I have already suggested seems overstated, not least because if we imagine even a very limited print run, perhaps along the lines of academic publishing today, it is hard to believe that such a market would have existed in sufficient numbers to merit the outlying costs of production.¹³ However, it could be that certain features — like the character list — were inflected to encode theatricality in ways that helped readers imagine the text as performance. Moreover, if we think of the character list functioning to model a particular mode of readerly engagement, it seems likely that

printers included them less as an acting aid and more as a shorthand for the kind of text they accompany; if we recall that the title page is far and away the most common position for such lists, it is possible to speculate that they offered potential buyers a way of immediately identifying the book in their hands as a play.

Nonetheless, it is the case that on the face of it, some character lists seem more concerned with performance than others, and this is particularly true of those lists that offer instructions for the doubling of parts. With the exception of the first edition of *Three Laws*, the doubling instructions that appear in around a quarter of all printed playbooks from our period function as an extension of the character list, and either provide a statement of the necessary number of players and/or give a schematised breakdown for the doubling of parts. In fact, while just three playbooks offer only a breakdown of roles, and a further six basic instructions regarding the pre-requisite number of players, in the majority of cases — some 13 in all — these two features are combined to provide a fully conceived, if not always reliable programme for economic casting. That this arrangement had some currency is supported by the appearance of a similar scheme on fol. 1^r of British Library Additional MS 26782, the sole witness to *A Marriage Between Wit and Wisdom*, which, as I have argued elsewhere, was clearly copied to resemble a printed edition, perhaps taking its lead from a volume like William Wager's *Enough is as Good as a Feast* (?1570; see FIG. 1).¹⁴

On the title page to *Enough is as Good as a Feast*, the generic instruction 'Seuen may easely play this Enterlude' precedes a list of 'The names of the Players', which has been arranged to show how the parts should be divided amongst the actors.¹⁵ In fact, the required number of actors is rather more than might be expected; while at least one other play requires eight players, a lower number is typical, with four the most common, particularly for plays printed earlier in our period. These lower figures tally with case made by E.K. Chambers and developed by David Bevington, that early Tudor interludes were originally performed by quasi-professional itinerant troupes of four or five men.¹⁶ And it may be that an awareness of these performance conditions informed a line in the collaborative play *Sir Thomas More* (composed c. 1590–1593), when one of the players explains to More that his troupe comprises 'foure men and a boy'.¹⁷ The higher numbers required by *Enough is as Good as a Feast* are similar to those given in the doubling instructions for four other plays printed after 1565

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FIG. 1: W. Wager *Inough is as good as a feast* (London: John Allde, [1570?]; STC 24933), sig. A1^r.

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and might simply reflect more elaborate production values in the decade before the opening of permanent professional theatres. However, given that these schemes were, from time to time, inaccurate, it seems as likely that instructions concerning the number of actors — particularly in the case of later plays — were intended to add an air of authenticity, to invoke the kind of performance conditions readers ought to envisage. So, while it is likely that playing companies formed one potential market for playbooks with detailed instructions for performance, the inclusion of such schemes may also have served to inculcate specific ways of reading. This conclusion is borne out by the instructions on the title page of *Lusty Juventus* that I cited at the beginning of this article: ‘foure may play it easely, takyng such par|tes as they thinke best: so that any one tak| of those partes that be not in place at once’. Jane Griffiths has recently argued that the wording of these instructions, which offer ‘a theoretical explanation of how doubling works’, may indicate that amateur rather than professional troupes were the intended market.¹⁸ But to me their generality points to an alternative possibility. Lacking the practical information required for the division of parts, and positing future performance in only the vaguest of terms, the doubling instructions for *Lusty Juventus*, which recur in two later editions of the play (both printed c. 1565), seem designed to aid readers as much as any would-be actors, professional or otherwise. In short, the character-list-cum-doubling-schemes that occur across a number of printed playbooks need not drive a wedge between performativity and readability — between drama and literature — but instead offer evidence of how printers worked to encode very particular kinds of reading experience, where the future performance of these plays is one that is imagined to take place in the mind.

Be that as it may, the kind of reading programme envisaged for plays with doubling instructions is clearly rather different to that intended for what are sometimes referred to as ‘closet’ dramas, those plays that we know were never intended for public performance, but were, rather, designed to be read or privately performed in the study or closet. 12 such plays (in 14 editions) survive from our period.¹⁹ The earliest, an anonymous translation of Terence’s *Andria* (c. 1520) was printed without a character list, but they do occur in the other 13. Nine are translations of Senecan tragedies, printed individually — and in the case of Jasper Heywood’s translation of *Troas*, in three separate editions (twice in 1559 and again in [?]1562) — but eventually compiled, with some revisions, as *Seneca his tenne tragedies* (1581). Two others are also translations, though of contemporary

continental plays. Only one — George Gascoigne's moral allegory, *The Glass of Government* (printed twice in 1575) — represents a new work by an English author. The character lists that are provided for these plays are never on the title page, but rather occur among a series of other prefatory paratexts. They tend to provide scant information — just a heading and a list of names — but are nonetheless presented on a page of their own, suggesting a kind of luxury that may have stood in as byword for literariness. The list provided for John Studley's translation of *Agamemnon* (1566) offers a typical example (see FIG. 2).

The list is the last of a lengthy series of prefatory paratexts that accompany the text, all of which contribute, in different ways, to heightening the overall impression of the work's literary and social import. After the title page there follows: from sig. ¶2^r to sig. A1^v a series of eight commendatory verses (two by Thomas Nuce, whose translation of Seneca's *Octavia* was printed in the same year; two by one W.R.; one each by a H.C., Thomas Delapeend — another translator, most famous for his partial translation of Ovid's *Metamorphosis* — W. Parkar, and one T.B.); on sig. A1^v, a list of 'fautes scaped in the verses'; a dedicatory 'Epistle' to William Cecil, the first Baron Burghley, from John Studley at sigs A2^r–A3^r; and a 'Preface to the Reader' on sigs A3^v–A4^r. Only after all of this other matter does the character list appear on sig. A4^v. With the exception of Cecil's arms, which appear beneath it, no other material occurs on the same page, with the result that the list stands out, isolated from the text on the adjacent recto. This effect is enhanced by the adoption of an italic font for the speakers' names, which may also have been intended to highlight the play's Latin source and identify its characters with the classical past. Although black-letter remained the dominant font for the presentation of plays until the 1590s, as early as the c. 1520 edition of *Andria* roman and italic fonts were used for Latin words and phrases. The mixing of fonts in the character list for *Agamemnon* is a piece with this practice, but goes one step further to suggest that italic is not only appropriate for Latin-language words, but also for signalling the literary culture of the ancient world.²⁰ That fonts could be key in the production of certain meanings is also clearly behind the presentation of the character list on fol. A2^r of Folger MS V. b. 221, a seventeenth-century adaptation of Henry Cheeke's 'closet' translation of Francesco Negri's *Free-Will* (?1573), which carefully replicates the blending of italic and roman fonts found in the original printed version of the list. Copied some fifty years after the translation was originally printed, and presumably intended for use by a particular reader or coterie

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FIG. 2: *The eyght tragedie of Seneca. Entitled Agamemon* translated John Studley
(London: Thomas Colwell, 1566; STC 22222), sig. A4^v
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of readers, the text of this manuscript copy varies greatly from Cheeke's printed translation, but the careful efforts to reproduce the mixing of fonts

as in the printed character list highlight the extent to which ‘closet’ texts and the character lists that almost universally accompanied them could signify meaning in very specific ways.

In fact, that character lists are found in all but one of the printed texts of ‘closet’ dramas from our period complicates the idea that such lists need always function to facilitate real, physical performance. Nonetheless, the formal differences between the lists found in these books and those with doubling schemes suggest they encode alternative horizons of reception. ‘Closet’ drama has often been described as an élite literary genre, and the careful inflection of character lists attached to such plays certainly indicates a mode of consumption distinct from other, more suggestively performative texts like those with elaborate doubling instructions.²¹ However, while these different kinds of playbook might have demanded different reading strategies, I am not convinced that they necessarily attracted different readers. While there is clearly further work to be done on the early ownership and use of sixteenth-century playbooks, it seems plausible that some readers of ‘closet’ texts may also have owned and read more popular plays. In short, the formal differences between character lists with doubling schemes and those included in the printed texts of ‘closet’ plays need not reflect implacable oppositions between drama and literature, the public and the private, or popular and élite modes of consumption. Rather, positioned towards the front of the book, character lists seem to have functioned like user-guides, offering the reader a sense of how he or she ought best approach the text, nuancing his or her understanding of the exact nature of the play.

A further kind of reading programme can be identified for 11 plays in 15 editions that provide relational descriptions for each of the characters.²² For if character lists with doubling instructions could serve to help readers picture the auspices for any imagined future performance, and character lists for ‘closet’ plays contribute to establishing the text’s literary value, then descriptive lists could be inflected to record past performance. The earliest example of a fully descriptive character list is John Bale’s *God’s Promises* (?1547), though in many ways this example is anomalous, as both the names of the characters and their descriptions are given in Latin.²³ Though there are few further examples from this earlier period, the practice became more common after 1570 — over half of the extant playbooks printed between 1570 and 1576 feature them. The list on the title page of *Jacob and Esau* (1568) offers a typical example. Here the ‘partes and names of the Players’ are listed in two columns, reading vertically:

- | | |
|-----------------------------|-----------------------------------|
| 1 The Prologe, a Poete. | 7 Hanan, a neighbour |
| 2 Isaac, an olde man, fa | to Isaac also |
| ther to Iacob & Esau. | 8 Ragau, a seruant vn- |
| 3 Rebecca an olde woman, | to Esau. |
| wife to Isaac. | 9 Mido, a little Boy, |
| 4 Esau, a yong man and a | leading Isaac. |
| hunter. | 10 Deborra, the nurse |
| 5 Iacob, a yong man of god- | of Isaacs Tente. |
| ly conuersation. | 11 Abra, a little wench, |
| 6 Zethar a neighbour. | seruant to Rebecca. ²⁴ |

With the exception of the Prologue, who enters and speaks first, all of the characters are described in relational terms to Isaac, who, as head of the family (and indeed the tribe of Israel), is the character invested with the most authority.

Describing characters in relational terms, such lists effectively plot the landscape of the play and we might think of them functioning in much the same way as contemporary maps in that their relationship to the plays they precede resembles that between cartographical representations and the lands they attempt to signify. Not for nothing was the map considered the first truly modern atlas printed with the title *Theatrum orbis Terrarum* (1570).²⁵ But, if plays with doubling instructions serve the possibility of future performance, these descriptive lists function to record and facilitate the imaginative reconstruction of past performance. That the time and place of the first performance is given in a third of all playbooks with such lists would seem to support this conclusion. For instance, the title page to *Gammer Gurton's Needle* (1575) informs the reader that the play was 'Played on| Stage, not longe| a go in Chri=|stes| Collidge in Cambridge', while the following verso provides a fully descriptive list of the characters' names.²⁶ Since there are no further references to original auspices in any of the other single-play playbooks printed before 1576, it seems very likely that these two paratexts — details of the first performance and details about the status and relationships between characters — were designed to go hand in hand in an effort to help the reader construct both the imaginative world of the play and the historical occurrence of its first performance.

In delineating three categories of character list — those with doubling instructions; those designed to accompany 'closet' plays; and those which describe characters in relational terms — I have attempted to demonstrate

that a single paratext could be manipulated to signify to readers different ways of encountering the text, but in doing so I have necessarily overstated some of the differences between them. In fact, while it is possible to trace broad trends, in reality there is much overlap, and in many cases individual lists borrow features from all three categories.

While all but one of the descriptive character lists for plays printed in the 1560s occur on the title page, the opposite is true of similar lists printed in the 1570s; with just two exceptions, all descriptive character lists that occur after 1570 appear after the title page, often among other prefatory paratexts. In this, they closely resemble the lists provided for 'closet' dramas. For example, the second, authorised edition of Thomas Norton and Thomas Sackville's *Gorboduc* (1570), includes a descriptive character list on sig. A2^v, in which the characters are described in terms of their relationship to 'Gorboduc, King of great Brittain'.²⁷ The title — 'The names of the speakers' — closely resembles those adopted for 'closet' texts; all of the Senecan translations printed before 1576 refer to characters as 'speakers' and the character list headings in two — *Agamemnon* and *Medea* (1566) — are virtually identical to the heading used for the list in *Gorboduc*.²⁸ At the same time, its position, after 'The argument' and 'The Preface to the Reader', but before an account of 'The order of the dome shew| before the first act, and the sig=|nification therof', approximates the content and layout of prefatory material associated with the publication of 'closet' texts, and suggests a similar preoccupation with framing the work for self-conscious readerly consumption. The 1570 edition of the play also includes commonplace markers, further compounding the sense that this text was designed primarily for literary purposes.²⁹ Such markers, here marginal single or double quotation marks, functioned in early modern printed books to identify lines or phrases of sententious merit that the careful reader could then commit to memory or copy into his or her commonplace book.³⁰ *Gorboduc* is the first known printed play to include such markers,³¹ and the programme of reading they point towards clearly aligns the play with those 'closet' texts that would have also been read for examples of pithy, moral advice.³² However, unlike any 'closet' translation, *Gorboduc* also proudly announces the moment of its original performance; the title page informs the potential buyer or reader that the text has been

set forth without addition or alte-|ration but altogether as the same
was shewed| on stage before the Queenes Maiestie,| about nine

years past, vz. The| xviii. day of Ianuarie. 1561.| by the gentlemen
of the| Inner Temple.³³

Status here is drawn from two supposedly opposing contexts: the socially elite, literary context of 'closet' drama, and the occasion of the play's performance before the Queen. Put another way, the character list for the second edition of *Gorboduc* indicates that its printer, John Day, may have sought ways to broaden its horizon of reception to appeal to a mixed market comprised of playgoers, those attracted to the imaginative process of recreating the play's original auspices, and those keen to encounter their drama as literature.

If the character list for a play like *Gorboduc* borrows from both the conventions associated with 'closet' drama those related to recording the historical moment of first performance, at least two others imply a different kind of mixed market, and combine the features of the descriptive character list with doubling schemes. The title page to *New Custom* (1573) provides a list of 'The players names in this| Enterlude', formatted in a single column with the characters' names given in roman type and descriptions provided in black letter.³⁴ However, in addition to this descriptive list, the title page also sets out a doubling scheme; beneath the instruction that 'fower may Play the Enterlude', the parts have been divided for four actors so that one man takes on the role of 'Peuersedoctrine' (*sic*), a second 'Ignoraunce| Hypocrisie.| and Education.', a third 'New Custome| Auarice.| Assurance.', while a fourth is required to act 'Light of the Gospell.| Creweltie.| Goddes felicitie.' and 'The prologue'.³⁵ In combining these features, the printer, William How, may have been seeking to maximise the book's market potential; in its printed form, the play seems both to account for past performance and enable the possibility of future performance. How printed a further three plays of which one — the anonymous *Common Conditions* (1576) — similarly blends a descriptive list with instructions for doubling. Like *New Custom*, this information occurs on the title page, with the list of 'The Players names' preceding the instruction that 'Six may play this Comedie'.³⁶ However, unlike *New Custom*, the title page does not provide more detailed information for the doubling of parts. One possible reason further instructions are omitted is that a production with just six actors would be impossible; as most editors of the play have realised, at least one scene requires no less than seven actors.³⁷ At the same time, the list itself provides separate entries for 'Metrea, a mayde' and 'Nomides, a knight that| loueth Metrea', the roles adopted by Clarisia and Sedmond, daughter

and son of the Duke of Arabia, when they are forced to flee their homeland and assume new identities.³⁸ Strikingly, this distinction between character and adopted persona is extended to the speech-prefixes used for the text itself, and may indicate that the text was set from a copy in which this distinction was similarly preserved. Be that as it may, it is tempting to attribute the faulty doubling scheme to a printer keen to get the job done quickly; the overall impression is of a book produced with less care than haste. In the end, far more than documenting actual past performance or facilitating real future performance, How seems most concerned with conveying *the idea* of performance. For it is the sense that the text could have been or might one day be performed that identifies it as a play and thereby informs the reader how it ought to be read.

Conclusions

In the recent turn towards reading in the field of drama studies, a number of critics have argued that the consumption of drama as literature can be dated to the 1590s, when the plays written for and performed in London's permanent playhouses were recognised as marketable print commodities.³⁹ The purpose of this article has been to demonstrate that in the decades before the establishment of commercial theatres there was already a market for printed drama that included readers as well as any would-be actors. Given the patchy nature of the evidence, any conclusions necessarily must be speculative.⁴⁰ Nonetheless, the character lists extant in the majority of plays printed before 1576 clearly contribute to the way these playbooks make meaning and may well have served to shape the way that these texts were used and read. While it seems likely that actors — professional or otherwise — must have made up one market for these playbooks, the multifarious forms adopted in the presentation of character lists suggest that by the mid-sixteenth-century printers were keen to extend their markets and attract different kinds of users, including those keen to read rather than perform drama. Far from functioning as a simple measure of performativity, the character lists that occur in early English plays are just one indication of the emerging market for Tudor drama as literature. Moreover, by encouraging readers to imagine performance, these texts model a particular kind of literary engagement that marks drama as a genre quite distinct from other forms of literature.

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Appendix I: Categories of Character List

Character lists can be categorised in a tantalising variety of ways. Here I provide lists of those with doubling instructions, those designed to accompany closet texts, and those that provide descriptions for each of the characters.⁴¹ All entries follow the bibliographic data as set out in the STC (second edition), though for ease of reference I have modernised and/or contracted some titles. I have also indicated the position of the character list for each entry. (Unless otherwise indicated, the place of publication is London.)

A: Character Lists with Doubling Instructions

This list includes those plays that provide a statement of the necessary number of players and/or give a schematised breakdown for the doubling of parts. Additional signature references are given for doubling schemes that occur separately to the character list.

John Bale *Three Laws* ([Wesel: Derick van der Straten, c. 1547]; STC 1287) sig. A1^v (doubling scheme at sig. G1^v).

R. Wever *Lusty Juventus* ([John Wyer for] Abraham Veale, [1550?]; STC 25148) sig. A1^r.

Impatient Poverty (John King, [1560]; STC 14112.5) sig. A1^r.

Impatient Poverty ([William Copland, 1561?]; STC 14113) sig. A1^r.

John Bale *Three Laws* (Thomas Colwell, 1562; STC 1288) sig. A1^r (doubling scheme at sig. A1^v).

Wealth and Heath ([William Copland for John Walley?, 1565?]; STC 14110) sig. A1^r.

R. Wever *Lusty Juventus* (John Awdely, [c. 1565]; STC 25149) sig. A1^r.

R. Wever *Lusty Juventus* (William Copland, [c. 1565]; STC 25149.5) sig. A1^r.

King Darius (Thomas Colwell, 1565; STC 6277) sig. A1^r.

John Phillips *Patient and Meek Grissel* (Thomas Colwell, [1566?]; STC 19865) sig. A1^r.

Lewis Wager *The Life and Repentance of Mary Magdalene* (John Charlewood, 1566; STC 24932) sig. A1^r.

Lewis Wager *The Life and Repentance of Mary Magdalene* (John Charlewood, 1567; STC 24932a) sig. A1^r.

John Pickeryng *Horestes* (William Griffith, 1567; STC 19917) sig. A1^r.

The Trial of Treasure (Thomas Purfoote, 1567; STC 24271) sig. A1^r.

Ulpian Fulwell *Like Will to Like* (John Allde, 1568; STC 11473) sig. A1^r.

- Ulpian Fulwell *Like Will to Like* (John Allde, [after 1568?]; STC 11473.5) sig. A1^r.
 W. Wager *The Longer Thou Livest* (William How for Richard Johnes, [1569]; STC 24935) sig. A1^v.
 Thomas Preston *Cambises* (John Allde, [1570?]; STC 20287) sig. A1^r.
 W. Wager *Enough is as Good as a Feast* (John Allde, [1570?]; STC 24933) sig. A1^r.
New Custom (William How for Abraham Veale, 1573; STC 6150) sig. A1^r.
Common Conditions (William How for John Hunter, [1576]; STC 5592) sig. A1^r.
 George Wapull *The Tide Tarrieth No Man* (Hugh Jackson, 1576; STC 25018) sig. A1^r.

B: 'Closet' Dramas that include Character Lists

This list follows play-type classifications as identified in *Annals of English Drama, 975–1700* edited Alfred Harbage, Samuel Schoenbaum, and Sylvia Stoler Wagonheim (London: Routledge, 3rd edition 1989):

- Seneca *Troas* translated Jasper Heywood (Richard Tottell, 1559; STC 22227) sig. A6^v.
 Seneca *Troas* translated Jasper Heywood (Richard Tottell, 1559; STC 22227a) sig. A6^v.
 Seneca *Thyestes* translated Jasper Heywood (Thomas Powell or Henry Wykes?, 1560; STC 22226) sig. ♣viii^v.
 Seneca *Hercules Furens* translated Jasper Heywood (Henry Sutton, 1561; STC 22223) sig. B1^r.
 Seneca *Troas* translated Jasper Heywood (Thomas Powell for George Buck, [1562?]; STC 22228) sig. A6^v.
 Seneca *Oedipus* translated Alexander Neville (Thomas Colwell, 1563; STC 22225) sig. aviii^v.
 Seneca *Agamemnon* translated John Studley (Thomas Colwell, 1566; STC 22222) sig. A4^v.
 Seneca *Medea* translated John Studley (Thomas Colwell, 1566; STC 22224) sig. A4^v.
 Seneca [sic] *Octavia* translated Thomas Nuce (Henry Denham, [1566]; STC 22229) sig. A4^v.
 Francesco Negri de Bassano *Free-Will* translated Henry Cheeke ([Richard Jugge, 1573?]; STC 18419) sig. A1^v.

Hendrik Niclaes *An Interlude of Minds* ([Cologne: Nickolaus Bohmberg, 1574?]; STC 18550) sig. A7^v.

George Gascoigne *The Glass of Government* ([Henry Middleton] for Christopher Barker, 1575; STC 11643) sig. π A2^v.

George Gascoigne *The Glass of Government* ([Henry Middleton] for Christopher Barker, 1575, STC 11643a) sig. π A2^v.

C: Plays with Descriptive Character Lists

The following list comprises all instances of fully descriptive character lists across our period. It omits lists for which descriptions are provided for some but not all of the characters.

John Bale *God's Promises* ([Wesel: Derick van der Straten, 1547?]; STC 1305) sig. A1^r.

Jack Juggler (William Copland, [1562?]; STC 14837) sig. A1^r.

Ravisius Textor *Thersites*, translated Nicholas Udall? (John Tisdale, [1562?]; STC 23949) sig. A1^r.

Jack Juggler (William Copland, [1565?]; STC 14837a) sig. A1^r.

Thomas Norton and Thomas Sackville *Gorboduc* (William Griffith, 1565; STC 18684) sig. A2^r.

Jacob and Esau (Henry Bynneman, 1568; STC 14327) sig. A1^r.

Jack Juggler (John Alde, [c. 1570]; STC 14837a.5) sig. A1^r.

Thomas Norton and Thomas Sackville *Gorboduc* (John Day, [1570]; STC 18685) sig. A2^v.

Richard Edwards *Damon and Pithias* ([William Williamson for] Richard Johnes, 1571; STC 7514) sig. A2^v.

New Custom (William How for Abraham Veale, 1573; STC 6150) sig. A1^r.

Francesco Negri de Bassano *Free-Will* edited Henry Cheeke ([Richard Jugge, 1573?]; STC 18419) sig. A1^v.

William Stevenson(?) *Gammer Gurton's Needle* (Thomas Colwell, 1575; STC 23263) sig. A1^v.

George Gascoigne *The Glass of Government* ([Henry Middleton] for Christopher Barker, 1575; STC 11643) sig. A2^v.

George Gascoigne *The Glass of Government* ([Henry Middleton] for Christopher Barker, 1575; STC 11643a) sig. A2^v.

Common Conditions (William How for John Hunter, [1576]; STC 5592) sig. A1^r.

Appendix II: Plays Without Character Lists

This list excludes plays for which there are only fragmentary copies, including those that, in their present state, lack a title page.

Henry Medwall *Fulgens and Lucrece* (London: John Rastell, [1512–1516]; STC 17778).

Hickscorner (Wynkyn de Worde, [1515?]; STC 14039).

Terence *Andria* (*Terens in englysh*) ([Paris: Philippe le Noir?, c. 1520]; STC 23894).

The World and the Child (Wynkyn de Worde, 1522; STC 25982).

Calisto and Melebea (John Rastell, [c. 1525]; STC 20721).

Gentleness and Nobility (John Rastell, [c. 1525]; STC 20723).

Everyman (John Skot, [1528?]; STC 10606).

Youth ([Wynkyn de Worde, c. 1530]; STC 14111).

Johan Johan (William Rastell, 1533; STC 13298).

John Heywood *The Pardoner and the Friar* (William Rastell, 1533; STC 13299).

Everyman ([John Skot, 1535?]; STC 10606.5).

Hickscorner ([William Copland for] John Waley, [1550?]; STC 14040).

John the Evangelist ([William Copland for] John Waley, [c. 1550]; STC 14643).

Youth ([John King for] John Waley; [1557]; STC 14111a).

A Mery Gest of Robin Hood (William Copland, [c. 1560]; STC 13691).

Youth (William Copland, [1565?]; STC 14112).

NOTES

I am grateful to the Bibliographical Society of America and the Folger Shakespeare Library for Short-Term Fellowships during which I undertook the research for and writing of this article.

1. R. Wever *An enterlude called lusty luuentus* (London: [John Wyer for] Abraham Vele, [1550?]; STC 25148) sig. A1^r. Two subsequent editions appeared in c. 1565 (STC 25149 and 25149.5), retaining these title-page instructions. Bibliographical references are drawn from *A Short-Title Catalogue of Books Printed in England, Scotland and Ireland, and of English Books Printed Abroad 1475–1640* edited A.W. Pollard and G.R. Redgrave, 2nd edition edited by W.A. Jackson, F.S. Ferguson, and K.F. Pantzer, 3 vols (London: The Bibliographical Society, 1976–1991), hereafter STC.

2. My focus is on single-play playbooks printed before the opening of The Theatre, of which the online *Database of Early English Plays* (hereafter *DEEP*) counts 91. To this figure, I have added a further two — second editions omitted by *DEEP* — but deducted those witnesses which are fragmentary, bringing my baseline for analysis to 79. This figure omits the seven plays that were printed in collection, since they occur in the very final years of my survey and represent a rather different kind of text. As this brief footnote highlights, statistical analysis is in many ways an exercise in definition and other catalogues and related tools arrive at alternative figures. The broader issues such disparities raise — including questions like ‘What is drama?’ or, ‘What is a playbook?’ — are beyond the scope of this article, but clearly have consequences for ongoing debates about the literary status of drama. For *DEEP* see <<http://deep.sas.upenn.edu>> (accessed 24 July 2014); for an alternative catalogue (in which drama is more widely defined) see Martin Wiggins and Catherine Richardson *British Drama 1533–1642: A Catalogue* 3 vols ongoing (Oxford UP, 2011–2013) 1 and 2.
3. Paul. J. Voss ‘Printing Conventions and the Early Modern Play’ *Medieval and Renaissance Drama in England* 15 (2003) 98–115 at 102.
4. For example, the title page to *Wealth and Health* ([London: William Copland for John Walley?, 1565?]; STC 14110) suggests a cast of four will be sufficient, when in reality at least five actors are required; similarly, *Common Conditions* (London: William How for John Hunter, [1576]; STC 5592) erroneously calls for six actors, when at least one scene requires seven. I return to such ‘false’ doubling schemes below at 52.
5. Greg Walker *The Politics of Performance in Early Renaissance Drama* (Cambridge UP, 1998) 23–4.
6. Tamara Atkin and Emma Smith ‘The Form and Function of Character Lists in Plays printed before the closing of the theatres’ *Review of English Studies* 65 (2014) 647–72.
7. My focus in this article is on single plays rather than plays in collections, so excluding the evidence of those cycle plays with medieval witnesses, the only fifteenth-century dramatic manuscripts that include a character list are the *Macro Wisdom* (Folger MS V. a. 354, fols 98^r–121^v) and *The Castle of Perseverance* (Folger MS V a. 354, fols 154^r–91^v). Two early-sixteenth-century copies of medieval plays, the Digby *Killing of the Children* (Oxford: Bodleian Library MS Digby 133, fols 95^r–157^v) and the Croxton *Play of the Sacrament* (Trinity College Dublin, MS F. 4. 20, fols 338^r–56^r), also feature character lists, but as I have argued elsewhere, it may be that these post-medieval witnesses followed the precedent of nascent print conventions. See Tamara Atkin ‘Playbooks and Printed Drama: A Reassessment of the Date and Layout of the

- Manuscript of the Croxton *Play of the Sacrament*' *Review of English Studies* 60 (2009) 194–204.
8. For a list of these plays, see Appendix 2.
 9. For a fuller discussion of these figures see Atkin and Smith 'Character Lists' 649–50.
 10. See the Macro *Wisdom*, *The Castle of Perseverance*, and the Digby *Killing of the Children*. The Croxton *Play of the Sacrament* post-dates the publication of Rastell's play.
 11. The STC dates the first edition to c. 1548. For further discussion of these two editions, including my alternative dating of the first edition and the paratextual alterations made to the second, see my article, 'Playing with Books in John Bale's *Three Laws*' *Yearbook of English Studies* 43 (2013) 243–61.
 12. One might expect plays that run to two or more editions to reveal important continuities and changes across our period, and yet overwhelmingly later editions simply reproduce the form and content of lists as they occur in earlier editions. Bale's *Three Laws* therefore provides a rare opportunity to glimpse at the different editorial procedures of different printers working with the same text. For further consideration of Bale's playbooks, including the extent of his involvement in the production of the c. 1547 imprints of *God's Promises*, *The Temptation of Our Lord*, and *Three Laws*, see Atkin 'Playing with Books'.
 13. This must have been particularly true after the 1572 'Act for the Punishment of Vagabonds', which effectively outlawed all troupes without noble patronage.
 14. Tamara Atkin 'Manuscript, Print, and the Circulation of Dramatic Texts: A Reconsideration of the Manuscript of *The Marriage of Wit and Wisdom*' *English Manuscript Studies 1100–1700*, 15 (2009) 152–65, in which I argue that the resemblance of the title-page of BL Add. MS 26782 to the title-pages of plays printed by John Alde indicates that the scribe had some awareness of what we might think of as Alde's 'house style'. However, the printing of plays was normally a very small part of the lifetime's output of individual printers; of the c. 65 titles printed by Alde, just seven were plays, and the features that make his playbooks readily identifiable do not extend to his non-dramatic output. For further discussion of the practices of individual printers in the presentation of early printed character lists, see Atkin and Smith 'Character Lists in Plays' 666–8.
 15. 'The Names of the Players' is the most common title for character lists in this period. It (or one of its variants) can found in around half of all extant plays with character lists. In fact, the title of a character list may have been one way of signalling a play's genre. The title 'The Names of the Players' occurs only in playbooks of Tudor interludes, whereas 'The Speakers', for instance, seems to have been the norm for translations of plays by classical or continental writers.

- I discuss the assignation 'Speakers' below at 59–60. For further discussion of character list headings see Atkin and Smith 'Character Lists in Plays' 658–61.
16. E.K. Chambers *The Medieval Stage* 2 vols (London: Oxford UP, 1903) 2 188; David Bevington *From Mankind to Marlowe: Growth of Structure in the Popular Drama of Tudor England* (Cambridge MA: Harvard UP, 1962) 11–14.
 17. Anthony Munday and others *Sir Thomas More* (Revels Plays Companion Library; Manchester UP, 2nd edition 2002) 3.3.72
 18. Jane Griffiths 'Lusty Juventus' in *The Oxford Handbook of Tudor Drama* edited Thomas Betteridge and Greg Walker (Oxford UP, 2012) 262–75 at 270.
 19. In my designation of certain plays as closet dramas, I follow the classifications adopted by *Annals of English Drama, 975–1700* edited Alfred Harbage, Samuel Schoenbaum, and Sylvia Stoler Wagonheim (London: Routledge, 3rd edition 1989).
 20. For further discussion of the ways printers used different typefaces in the presentation of character lists, see Atkin and Smith 'Cast Lists in Plays' 653–4.
 21. On 'closet' drama as an élite literary genre see, for instance, Marta Straznicky *Privacy, Playreading, and Women's Closet Drama, 1550–1700* (Cambridge UP, 2004).
 22. I omit from discussion those character lists for which a description is provided for only one or two of the characters. In such lists, the Vice is the character most commonly singled out for description; four plays (in nine editions) identify the Vice without providing descriptions for any of the other characters.
 23. Though the characters are provided with Latin names in the character list, vernacular speech-prefixes are used throughout the play; the same is true of the two other extant editions of plays by Bale printed by Derick van der Straten in c. 1547.
 24. *A neue mery and wittie comedie or enterlude, newly imprinted, treating vpon the historie of Iacob and Esau* (London: Henry Bynneman, 1568) sig. A1^r. This is the second edition of this play. The first edition was printed in (?)1557, and survives in a single copy recorded in the catalogue of the library at New College, Oxford. However, as this copy has not been located since 2008, it is impossible to comment on the extent to which the second edition adopts the *mise en page* of the first.
 25. The idea of the world as a stage and the stage as a world were metaphors widely used by scholars and playwrights throughout our period and beyond. See Tom Conley 'Pierre Boaistuau's Cosmographic Stage: Theater, Text, and Map' *Renaissance Drama* 23 (1992) 59–86.
 26. William S[tevenson?] *A ryght pithy, pleasaunt and merie comedie: intytuled Gammer gurtens nedle* (London: Thomas Colwell, 1575; STC 23263) sig A1^r.
 27. Thomas Norton and Thomas Sackville *The Tragidie of Ferrex and Porrex* (London: John Day, [1570]; STC 18685) sig. A2^r. An earlier, pirated edition

- appeared in 1565 (STC 18684). Although this edition does include a descriptive character list (on sig. A2^r), it lacks some of the prefatory matter included in the second edition.
28. *Gorboduc* sig. A2^r.
 29. Zachary Lesser and Peter Stallybrass 'The First Literary *Hamlet* and the Commonplacing of Professional Plays' *Shakespeare Quarterly* 59 (2008) 371–420.
 30. On the function of commonplace markers, see Margreta de Grazia 'Shakespeare in Quotation Marks' in *The Appropriation of Shakespeare: Post-Renaissance Reconstructions of the Works and the Myth* edited Jean I. Marsden (New York: St Martin's Press, 1991) 57–71.
 31. Lesser and Stallybrass 'Hamlet and Commonplacing' 385.
 32. At least one reader did approach his copy of the text in this way: William Briton copied 24 extracts of the play into British Library Additional MS 61822 (The Houghton Manuscript). Though the extracts he chose to copy do not tally with those marked for commonplacing in Day's edition, they indicate a similar interest in sententious wisdom. On William Briton as an early reader of the play, see Laura Estill 'New Contexts for Early Tudor Plays: William Briton, an early reader of *Gorboduc*' *Early Theatre* 16 (2013) 197–210.
 33. *Gorboduc* sig. A1^r.
 34. *A new enterlude no lesse wittie: then pleasant, entituled new custome* (London: William How for Abraham Veale, 1573; STC 6150) sig. A1^r.
 35. *New Custom* sig. A1^r.
 36. *Common Condictions* sig. A1^r.
 37. See, for instance, Roberta Barker's Introduction to her edition of *Common Conditions* (Oxford: Malone Society, 2004) v–xxi at vi.
 38. *Common Conditions* sig. A1^r.
 39. See, for instance, *From Performance to Print in Shakespeare's England* edited Peter Holland and Stephen Orgel (Basingstoke: Palgrave Macmillan, 2006); John Jowett *Shakespeare and Text* (Oxford UP, 2007); Sonia Massai *Shakespeare and the Rise of the Editor* (Cambridge UP, 2007); and Holger Syme 'Thomas Creede, William Barley, and the Venture of Printing Plays' in *Shakespeare's Stationers: New Essays in Cultural Bibliography* edited Marta Straznický (Philadelphia: University of Pennsylvania Press, 2013) 28–46.
 40. The fragmentary state of so many early printed plays provides some indication of the number of copies — perhaps even whole editions — that have not survived.
 41. For other ways of categorising lists according to their arrangement, typeface, punctuation, heading etc. see Atkin and Smith 'Character Lists in Plays' 652–8.